

pen and that's how we pushed the *Baahubali* films," says Yarlagaadda, CEO & Co-founder of Arka Mediaworks. Elsewhere, amid Bollywood's bustle, the little fly caught the attention of film distributor Anil Thadani. "Actually, my first attempt of working with Rajamouli sir was in *Makkhi*. Someone beat me to it. After I missed the bus in *Makkhi*, I realised *Baahubali* is a film I will never let go at whatever cost," says the Founder of AA Films.

When Rajamouli walked into the Arka Mediaworks office with a grand idea about a woman crossing a river with baby in her hand, the producers knew it had to be taken to the rest of the country to recover the costs. With their combined learnings from the past, they assembled a team of Dharma Productions, AA Films and Mumbai-based PR agency Spice to present, distribute and market the film in the North. Nearly three years, several sleepless nights and ₹180 crore in total budget later, *Baahubali: The Beginning* was ready for release in July 2015.

The talk in the Dharma office was that the Hindi version would make ₹15-20 crore, says Yarlagaadda. "That was disappointing because it would not have even recovered the marketing costs." When release day dawned, prospects seemed even bleaker. It seemed the film would be washed out even in Telugu. "There was a moment when we were thinking, 'Would it mean that we might have to do without the second part?'" he laughs nervously now. But the collections started picking up in the evening, and raced through the roof. More important than the ₹500 crore that the movie raked in was the fact that it overshot their estimation in Hindi by more than 7.5x, mopping up ₹150 crore gross, while holding its own against Salman Khan's *Bajrangi Bhaijaan*. "It's all credit to Anil Thadani. He insisted that we need a lot more screens for the Hindi-dubbed version," says Yarlagaadda, breaking into a smile, the relief evident on his face even after all these years.

To be fair, this is not the first time south Indian films dubbed into Hindi are working well theatrically. Distributors roll out the names of successful movies by Tamil film-makers Mani Ratnam and Shankar—*Roja*, *Bombay*, *Hindustani*, *Robot* and, more recently, 2.0 with Akshay Kumar as the villain. Those in the trade are also quick to caution that for the handful of films that have worked, several more haven't. For instance, Prabhas-starrer *Radhe Shyam*, which was pushed in Hindi on the might of the *Baahubali* actor, tanked. "Five out of 200 south Indian films have worked pan-India during this time. Bollywood should have released 70 films but only 20 released finally because the rest went to OTTs. The success rate in films is 5-10 per cent. This ratio is true for films from North and South," says Jayantilal Gada, Chairman & MD of Pen India. He calls it a temporary effect, in part



THE SOUTH INDIAN STARDUST

The Secret of their Success...

- 1 Cinematic storytelling style with ample room for larger-than-life action sequences and special effects
- 2 Fan following cultivated among the Hindi-speaking masses over two decades through re-runs of Hindi-dubbed south Indian films on satellite TV
- 3 Content which appeals to a wider audience, including the single-screen audience, neglected by Hindi film producers

...And their Impact

- 1 Production budgets for south Indian films, especially those with a pan-India appeal, are shooting up because a wider market means higher chances of budget recovery; ₹500-crore productions are becoming common
- 2 It also helps that OTT platforms pick up digital rights at hefty rates even before the film's theatrical release. Non-theatrical rights cover 50-75 per cent of the film's budget and reduce the producer's risk
- 3 Over time, OTTs can open up theatrical releases for films in less explored international markets as global audiences discover these films on OTT platforms